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Dhikr rituals and culture change

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A Dhikr Ritual in the Resettled Village of Kanuba

One of the men was requested by the others to chant some of the Qur'ān, which he did, imitating the famous chanters of Cairo who are often heard on the village radio. The chanter worked himself into a deep trance, and finally became so excited by his efforts that several men standing nearby forcibly stopped him, shaking him back to consciousness. One of them shouted, "*Bas! Bas!*" (Enough! Enough!) evoking laughter from the group by using the same tone mothers employ with children. Several jokes were heard in the background. At this point two boys entered the courtyard with censers and passed the incense to everyone, allowing each person to inhale the smoke for a few seconds. The incense was followed by cinnamon tea in small cups.

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After this brief interlude, which relaxed the tension, one of the young leaders picked up a drum. Looking straight at the imām he tapped it twice in direct opposition to the leader's orders. Seeing that his wishes were going to be countermanded, the latter arose in anger and calling two of his followers, stalked out of the courtyard.

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No sooner had the opposition departed when the Popular leader hit the drum with several swift beats and clapped his hands, signaling for the *dhikr* to proceed. Most of the men then formed two lines facing one another, simulating the *maglis* form of the traditional Nubian *dhikr*. Meanwhile, the women, who were grouped around the doorway to the courtyard, began to shake their arms violently in rhythm with the loud beating of tambourines. "Allāh hayy! Allāh hayy!" ("God lives!") the crowd shouted again and again.

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Now the feigned seriousness was gone, and the affair took on the air of an uninhibited leaping dance. At one point the *dhikr* lines broke up and one man began imitating the movements of a traditional Nubian female dancer, running into the middle of the circle with a shuffling effeminate step. The dancing, shouting men made a wide circle around him, first closing in and then opening out again in time with the drumming. It was a humorous caricature of a Nubian wedding dance. The dancer became so excited that he grabbed a long pointed metal rod, and as he danced, brandished it half-menacingly at various members of the taunting crowd.

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The huddled women and children still were watching through the door of the other courtyard, at times unleashing penetrating joy-cries. These *zagharīt* did not seem to have any particular order or timing, as they had in Diwān, but were rather more like enthusiastic impulsive shouts. Some boys of around twelve and thirteen years of age then joined the dancing and added their antics to those of the young men.

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Several older men who were not participating in this informal *dhikr* sat  54 around the fringe of the courtyard and seemed to be enjoying the entertainment. At one side we saw a man asleep on a bench and noted that he was one of the troublemakers of the village, a self-appointed unwanted "leader" who often expressed boredom with any kind of community celebration or ritual activity. Another man, who had recently returned from Cairo and who had traveled abroad as a cook for a wealthy official for many years, did not seem to know even the basic pattern of the *dhikr*. He could not follow what the rest of them were doing, and, though trying hard, always seemed out of step with the entire proceeding. Twice during this performance one of the young leaders of the village came over to us and whispered that people were simply enjoying themselves and therefore their profanations of sacred ritual should not be held against them.

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